manner of putting across national concerns and his focus on socio-economic advancement. It also gave me a glimpse of a thinking that, after 2014, would drive the endeavour towards cultural rebalancing.

The second contact was an indirect one, around the time of the 2014 general election. It was widely speculated even ahead of the counting that there could be a change of guard. As Ambassador in Washington, D.C., it was my duty to plan for all contingencies. Discreet preparations were accordingly made for an early phone conversation between President Barack Obama and the Indian PM-designate. In this particular case, there was more than just logistical and protocol issues to worry about. Addressing the overhang from the past was clearly a significant concern. In the event, this was effectively finessed. But the episode does bring out PM Modi's instinct to put national interest ahead and take a strategic approach towards a potentially important partner.

Any account of this period must necessarily include a reference to the Madison Square Garden event in 2014. This is not so much because of the event in itself but because it began a trend in diaspora connection and public projection that continues to this day. In my first meeting with PM Modi, the idea came up in the context of the impact of the diaspora and shaping India's image abroad. I was essentially told that the gathering must be organized in New York in such a manner that its reverberations would first reach Washington, D.C., and then be a message across the world. Since that experience, this has emerged as a signature aspect of Modi diplomacy that has travelled successfully across nations and continents. Leaders of the democratic world are obviously enthralled and often keen to participate. From Denmark and Japan to Africa and Australia, this is seen akin to a political rock concert.

For the diaspora, it has been a motivation and recognition at the same time. And not least, this has emerged as a high-profile platform to share the 'India Story' with the world, constantly refreshing it with updates. This concern for the diaspora itself emerges from a combination of factors. It expresses appreciation for their continued contribution to India's welfare. At the same time, enthusing them does encourage efforts to make their society of domicile more interested in India. But there is also the deeper issue of preparing Indians for the era of a global workplace. This requires facilitating their mobility, enhancing their ease of living abroad, addressing specific concerns of students, professionals, etc., and, most important,